

Modal verbs

Modal	Function	Explanation	Examples
MUST	Obligation, duty, strong necessity	It is your duty to do it/ you are obliged to do it/ you need to do it very much	I must become a good specialist to have this job. (<i>you are obliged to become if you want this job</i>)
	Prohibition	You are not allowed to do it/ it is against the rules (law) / forbidden	You mustn't smoke here. (<i>it is against the rules</i>)
	Strong advice	Someone recommends (strongly advises) to do something	You must apologize for what had happened. (<i>you really should do it not to have further troubles</i>)
	Logical assumptions	a) positive logical assumptions (<i>must = I am certain/ sure</i>) b) for negative logical assumptions one should use <i>can't</i>	a) It must be Julia Roberts. (<i>I'm sure she is</i>) b) It can't be Bart Simpson. (<i>I'm sure he isn't Bart</i>)
Must is used to talk about present or nearest future. When other tenses are needed, we use <i>have to</i> .			
HAVE TO	Inevitable obligation, inevitable duty or necessity	Something was decided for the speaker very often against the speaker's will	I have to write a composition (<i>someone has decided</i>) I have to use bus today, my car is broken. (<i>inevitable necessity, no other options</i>)
	Lack of necessity	Something is not necessary to be done	You don't have to buy this dress. (<i>no need to do it</i>)
<i>Have got to</i> has the same meaning as <i>have to</i> and it is commonly used in everyday speech. For example: Mark has got to leave in order to arrive at the airport in time.			
NEED	Necessity	You need to do something but it's not so strong in comparison with <i>must</i>	I need to see this exercise. (<i>you need for some purpose</i>)
	Lack of necessity	It isn't necessary to do something, it wasn't necessary or it won't be	You didn't need to bring it. (<i>there was no need to do it</i>)
	Fulfilled unnecessary action	Something was done in the past that wasn't necessary or obligatory	You needn't have bought me flowers, Brad. (<i>But Brad had bought the flowers</i>)
CAN	Ability in the present	The ability to do something in present, to have the necessary skill	I can dance. (<i>I'm able to dance, I have the skill at present</i>)
	Asking permission	When you use <i>can</i> you get an informal request for permission	Can I stay here tonight? (<i>You may ask like that people you know</i>)
	Giving / refusing permission	When you use <i>can</i> you get an informal permission or refusing it	You can / can't have this toy. (<i>You allow or don't</i>)
	Offer / suggestion	We can use <i>can</i> to offer something or to ask someone to do something for us	We can go to the theatre. (<i>offer</i>) Can we dance now? (<i>suggestion</i>)
COULD	Ability in the past	Something that person was able to do in the past, had necessary skill to do it	I could swim faster. (<i>in the past I did it better</i>)
	Polite request / offer	When you use <i>could</i> you get a more formal request for permission	Could I do anything for you? (<i>polite offer of your help</i>) Could you help me? (<i>polite request</i>)
	Possibility	a) it is possible/ perhaps/ it is likely b) it was possible but it didn't happen	a) Lisa is late. She could be tired after the party. (<i>likely</i>) b) The author could have received a prize (<i>but he didn't</i>)
We use <i>was/were able to</i> (=managed to do) to show that someone had an ability to do some single action in the past. Example: She was able to finish her work in time. Also we use <i>be able to</i> instead of <i>can</i> in future tenses			

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MAY	Possibility	We use <i>may</i> to tell about possibilities in present or future, it gives you the sense of uncertainty	- Where is Jack? – He may still be at work. (<i>It's possible that he is still at work</i>)
	Asking permission	May I (do something) is equal to the construction <i>mind if I</i> . We tend to use <i>may</i> when we don't know the person we talk to very much	May I ask you a few questions more, sir? (<i>This phrase can be used during an interview or an interrogation</i>)
	Giving / refusing permission	<i>May</i> is more formal than <i>can</i> . This function is not so often used in everyday speech, though it is widely used on different notes about rules	Passengers may take only one item of a hand baggage on board. (<i>more often it's written on notes than said</i>)
MIGHT	Possibility in the past	We use <i>might</i> to tell about possibilities in the past. We can talk about past actions that were possibly true or possibly but didn't happen	- The keys are inside. – Helen might have forgotten them. (<i>Perhaps, Helen forgot the keys</i>) You are crazy! You might have been killed! (<i>Luckily, you weren't</i>)
	Asking permission	Might I (do something) is equal to the construction <i>mind if I</i> . But it sounds even more formal than <i>may</i>	Might I interrupt you, Your Majesty? (<i>a great respect is displayed here</i>)
SHALL	Offers	We use <i>shall</i> to offer our help in order to do something	Shall I help you choose your mother's present? (<i>you offer your assistance in the choice</i>)
	Suggestions	We use <i>shall</i> as an invitation to do something. It's equal to <i>Why don't we / How about / Let's</i>	Shall we go for a walk tonight? (<i>Why don't we go for a walk tonight</i>)
	Asking for suggestions or instructions	We can also use <i>shall</i> when we want to receive some necessary suggestions or instructions	What shall we do next to fix it? (<i>a request for further instructions</i>)
SHOULD	Advice	This advice is a recommendation much less stronger than <i>must</i>	You should talk to your brother (<i>It's a good idea to talk to him</i>)
	Criticism	We use <i>should</i> to show that somebody did something wrong in the past / to criticize actions	You should have tried better. (<i>But they didn't and their team lost</i>)
OUGHT TO	Advice	This advice is a recommendation much less stronger than <i>must</i> , but stronger than <i>should</i>	You ought to talk to your brother (<i>It's a very good idea to talk to him, it may help</i>)
	Criticism	We use <i>ought to</i> in order to show that somebody did something wrong in the past / to criticize	You ought to have tried better. (<i>But they didn't and their team lost</i>)

Synonymous usage:

Mustn't = Can't (prohibition / it is forbidden to)	You mustn't / can't park your car beside the gate.
Needn't = Don't (doesn't) need to = Don't have to (no necessity to do something)	Neil needn't / doesn't need to / doesn't have to wash his car tomorrow, because he did it today.
Can / Could / May / Might I = Do you/ Would you mind if I	Can/ Could/ May/ Might I open the received file?
Can / Could / Shall I = Would you like me to	Can/ Could/ Shall I help you with your suitcases?
Could = May = Might (possibility, it is likely)	His jacket is here. He could/ may/ might be at home.
Could = Might (possible, but didn't happen)	The dancer could/ might have been hurt during the performance of this hard trick.
Could = May = Might (possibility in the past, it was likely)	He could/ may/ might have met his friend at the pub.
Shall/ Can/ Could = Why don't we/ Let's/ How about	Shall/ Can/ Could we go to the cinema tonight?
Should = Ought to (advice, criticism)	You should/ ought to be more attentive. They should/ ought to have played better to win the game.

Exercises

Input the correct modal verb

Each modal verb is to be used once

have to	should	can't
could	needn't	must

- It _____ be Carlos. I'm sure it is his Porsche.
- You _____ listen to your mother, she is a professional in this area.
- _____ you be so kind to open the front door for me?
- Glen doesn't _____ wake up early as it is his day off.
- The flowers are nice but you _____ have bought them.
- Why _____ you speak English if you father is an Englishman?

Define the function

Circle the function the modal verb stands for

- I have to tell you that your car has been stolen.
a)possibility; b)unnecessary action; c)inevitable obligation
- Shall I make some for your guests as well?
a)advice; b)criticism; c)offer; d)asking permission
- You needn't have taken those books, the library doesn't work today as it is a sanitary day.
a)criticism; b)fulfilled unnecessary action; c)advice; d)offer
- Mark should talk to his brother to calm him down.
a)offer; b)advice; c)prohibition; d)necessity
- What shall we do next to assemble this equipment?
a)asking for instructions; b)offer; c)necessity; d)advice
- It must be my mum; she always calls me about this time.
a)obligation; b)prohibition; c)logical assumption; d)criticism
- You mustn't cross the school rules not to be eliminated.
a)prohibition; b)advice; c)logical assumption; d)criticism
- May I open the window, please? It's too hot in here.
a)ability; b)criticism; c)possibility; d)asking permission
- Larry is too late. He could be lost somewhere in park.
a)asking permission; b)possibility; c)advice; d)offer
- You can't have this game, you behaved badly all the week.
a)advice; b)lack of necessity; c)refusing permission; d)offer
- You ought to have tried better to win the championship!
a)criticism; b)inevitable obligation; c)advice; d)possibility

Underline the best option

- You **aren't able/mustn't** park your car under this sign.
- You **can/should** dance with me if you want.
- You **needn't/could** have bought me flowers, I'm just glad to see you.
- What **might/shall** they do to assemble the device within an hour?
- You **had to/should** have tried better to achieve the best result possible.
- You **can't/needn't** do this trick if you don't have the necessary skill level.
- He **might/shall** have met his friends at the pub; otherwise I don't know why he is late.
- Shall/Need** I help you with your test? – Yes, please, some tasks are extremely difficult.
- The worker **may/might** have been hurt during the accident on the construction site.
- You **don't ought to/don't have to** listen to him if you think he is wrong for sure.

Exclude the wrong one

Cross out the modal that can't be used

- His car can be seen. He _____ be at work.
a)could; b)may; c)should; d)might
- _____ I help you with your suitcase?
a)could; b)can; c)need; d)shall
- _____ we go to the theatre tonight?
a)must; b)can; c)could; d)shall
- Justin _____ to get ready for his exam tomorrow morning as he did it today.
a)needn't; b)shouldn't; c)doesn't need; d)doesn't have to
- You _____ put your things on the railing, it is against the mall rules.
a)mustn't; b)can't; c)needn't;
- Larry _____ have been expelled last week because of his failed exams.
a)could; b)must; c)might